

Miami - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | ACC

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ♦ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Legitimate top-10 / playoff-contender quality with a proven imported quarterback, elite skill anchors and a defense that was genuinely dominant in 2025.
Preseason consensus	No. 7 (1,379 points; 1 first-place vote) · ACC No. 1 (3,159 points; 165 first-place votes) · No. 7
Returning production	57% (No. 51) overall · Off. 54% (No. 69) · Def. 59% (No. 40)
Primer power rating	+22.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	10.0 wins · most likely 10-2
Net vs. 2025	● ↓ - Slight regression in continuity from a 13-win 2025 team, especially along the offensive and defensive fronts.
Confidence	Medium-high

2026 identity: Shannon Dawson's offense can be built around established QB Darian Mensah, All-America WR Malachi Toney and RB Mark Fletcher Jr., with WR Cooper Barkate adding another major target while two offensive-line jobs remain open.

Bottom line: Miami is a credible playoff team because the quarterback/skill ceiling and defensive core remain elite, but replacing multiple drafted linemen and edge stars makes the No. 7 consensus a projection that still has to survive front-line turnover.

Beats expectations if: QB Darian Mensah fits Dawson's adaptable system immediately, the final OL five protects well enough for WR Malachi Toney/WR Cooper Barkate/RB Mark Fletcher Jr. to drive explosives, and the rebuilt front preserves most of the 2025 defensive efficiency.

Disappoints if: The line rebuild creates protection/rushing inconsistency, the receiver room thins after WR Cam Vaughn's dismissal, and the front cannot replace DL Rueben Bain Jr./DL Akheem Mesidor without losing too much havoc or run defense.

Five things to remember

- 1 National baseline:** Miami is a true consensus top-seven team: AP No. 7, SP+ No. 7 and No. 1 in the ACC preseason poll with 165 first-place votes.
- 2 QB stability:** QB Darian Mensah is the established imported QB1 and the ACC preseason player of the year.
- 3 ★ WR Malachi Toney:** WR Malachi Toney is an AP/Walter Camp first-team All-American, while RB Mark Fletcher Jr. adds AP second-team/ACC first-team recognition as the proven lead back.
- 4 2025 baseline:** The 2025 Miami defense was elite by both raw and advanced measures: scoring defense No. 5, opponent-adjusted defense No. 4, defensive success rate No. 9 and havoc created No. 11.
- 5 NFL departures:** The biggest counterweight is professional attrition: Miami had nine NFL draft picks plus four additional confirmed NFL rookie paths.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	13-3 (6-2 ACC)	● Excellent
Scoring	30.9 PPG	● Very good
Total offense	405.0 YPG	● Good / above average
Rush offense	151.8 YPG · 4.3 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass efficiency	8.18 YPA · 32 TD / 12 INT	● Elite
Third downs	46.0%	● Very good
Scoring defense	14.8 PPG allowed	● Elite
Total defense	294.1 YPG allowed	● Elite
Rush defense	89.2 YPG · 3.0 YPC	● Elite
Pass defense	204.9 YPG · 6.29 YPA · 13 TD allowed	● Very good

Miami was excellent in the places that most directly translate to winning: scoring defense No. 5, rush defense No. 6, pass efficiency No. 13 and third downs No. 24. Total offense was a less dominant No. 47 and rushing No. 77, so the 13-win record was not simply the product of overwhelming yardage on every snap.

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	+9.71 · No. 9	● Elite
Off. EPA/play	+0.174 · No. 14	● Elite
Off. success rate	50.1% · No. 10	● Elite
Off. explosive-play rate	11.8% · No. 71	● Average / mixed
Havoc allowed	12.1% · No. 19	● Very good
Opp.-adjusted defense	+11.77 · No. 4	● Elite
Def. EPA/play allowed	-0.185 · No. 7	● Elite
Def. success rate allowed	34.5% · No. 9	● Elite
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	9.8% · No. 21	● Very good
Havoc created	19.0% · No. 11	● Elite

Advanced-stat read: Miami’s 13-win 2025 season was backed by elite play-level performance rather than close-game noise.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	Mario Cristobal - returning	● ↔ Mario Cristobal's return keeps the overall program structure stable.
OC / offensive play-caller	Shannon Dawson - Returning OC/QB; offensive play-caller entering fourth season directing the offense	● ↔ Shannon Dawson enters a fourth season directing the offense, preserving system and caller continuity.
DC / defensive play-caller	Corey Hetherman - Returning DC/LB and returning defensive play-caller	● ↔ Corey Hetherman's return keeps the defensive system and primary play-caller intact.

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ QB Darian Mensah	Duke	● ↔ Replaces drafted starter QB Carson Beck.
◆ WR Cooper Barkate	Duke	● ↑ Projects for a starting/major role and brings Biletnikoff recognition opposite/alongside WR Malachi Toney.
◆ OL Jamal Meriweather	Georgia	● ↔ Competes for one of the two unresolved OL jobs.

Out	To	Loss
QB Carson Beck	NFL (Arizona), Round 3, No. 65	● ↔ The 2025 starting QB leaves.
OL Francis Mauigoa	NFL (N.Y. Giants), Round 1, No. 10	● ↓ The No. 10 overall pick removes premium tackle talent from a line that still has two open spots.
OL Markel Bell	NFL (Philadelphia), Round 3, No. 68	● ↓ Another high-level lineman leaves for the NFL, compounding the best-five rebuild.
C James Brockermeier	NFL (Atlanta), undrafted free agent	● ↓ The starting center leaves via a confirmed Falcons UDFA path.
WR CJ Daniels	NFL (L.A. Rams), Round 6, No. 197	● ↓ A material 2025 receiving contributor departs.
WR Cam Vaughn	Dismissed from program	● ↓ Productive incoming transfer expected to compete for major snaps was dismissed Aug. 17, removing a current-roster option.

Offensive net: ● ↓ Roughly similar top-end skill quality but worse line continuity.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ DL Damon Wilson II	Missouri	● ↑ Projects as a starting edge/front player and carries a Bednarik watchlist signal.
◆ DL Keona Davis	Nebraska	● ↔ Adds major rotation depth to a front replacing multiple NFL players.
◆ DB Omar Thornton	Boston College	● ↔ Fits a nickel/multi-position role and helps preserve Hetherman's multiplicity after secondary departures.

Out	To	Loss
DL Rueben Bain Jr.	NFL (Tampa Bay), Round 1, No. 15	● ↓ The No. 15 pick removes a premium front player from a defense whose havoc was a defining 2025 strength.
DL Akheem Mesidor	NFL (L.A. Chargers), Round 1, No. 22	● ↓ Another first-round defensive lineman departs, creating a rare amount of high-end front replacement work.
LB Wesley Bissainthe	NFL (Kansas City), undrafted free agent	● ↓ A material starting linebacker exits via confirmed Chiefs UDFA path.
DB Jakobe Thomas	NFL (Minnesota), Round 3, No. 98	● ↓ A drafted defensive back departs from a secondary that still retains S Fitzgerald/Frederique/Lucas/Poyser anchors.

Defensive net: ● ↓ Modest downgrade in proven front-line star power but still a high-end defense.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	Dawson describes a system that morphs around player strengths.	Mensah’s processing/deep-ball fit, WR Toney/Fletcher/WR Barkate/Lofton and a 2025 offense that ranked top-14 in EPA/play.	Two OL spots remain close after several NFL departures.
Defense	Hetherman’s returning defense is aggressive and multiple.	The 2025 unit was top-five adjusted, top-10 in success-rate defense and top-11 in havoc.	Bain and DL Mesidor were first-round losses.
Special teams	Punter is more settled than kicker.	Dylan Joyce has Ray Guy recognition and a high-confidence projected role.	Olsen/Weinberg remains an open kicker competition.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● A-	● ↔	High	QB Darian Mensah arrives as the established QB1 and ACC preseason player of the year, limiting post-QB Carson Beck uncertainty.
RB	● A-	● ↔	High	RB Mark Fletcher Jr. returns as a proven lead back with AP second-team/ACC first-team recognition.
WR	● A	● ↔	Medium-high	WR Malachi Toney is a first-team All-American and WR Cooper Barkate adds Biletnikoff-level upside, though depth thinned after WR Cam Vaughn’s dismissal.
TE	● B+	● ↔	Medium-high	TE Elija Lofton returns with Mackey recognition and an established role in a deep skill group.
OL	● B	● ↓	Medium	OL Samson Okunlola/OL Matthew McCoy provide quality anchors, but two jobs remain open after multiple NFL losses.
DL/Edge	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	DL Ahmad Moten Sr./DL Damon Wilson II headline a deep front replacing first-rounders DL Rueben Bain Jr./DL Akheem Mesidor.
LB	● B+	● ↓	Medium-high	LB Mohamed Toure provides first-team ACC/Butkus recognition after the loss of LB Wesley Bissainthe.
Secondary	● A-	● ↓	Medium-high	S Bryce Fitzgerald leads a talented returning core, but the unit still replaces drafted DB Jakobe Thomas and other experience.
Special teams	● B	● ↔	Medium	P Dylan Joyce is established and Ray Guy-recognized; kicker remains an open competition.
Coaching	● A-	● ↔	High	HC Mario Cristobal, OC Shannon Dawson and DC Corey Hetherman all return with play-calling continuity.
Overall	● A-	● ↓	Medium-high	Top-seven quality remains, but both lines must absorb unusually significant NFL attrition.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 23, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Malachi Toney	WR	● National star / primary offensive weapon	AP first team · Walter Camp first team · ACC first team · Biletnikoff Award · Maxwell Award	Miami’s clearest elite skill player and the centerpiece of the passing game around Mensah.
◆ Darian Mensah (TR: Duke)	QB	● High-end conference starter / national breakout candidate	ACC preseason player of the year · ACC first team · Maxwell Award	Established imported QB1 whose certainty and recognition keep the post-QB Carson Beck transition from becoming the primary risk.
Mark Fletcher Jr.	RB	● National high-end starter	AP second team · ACC first team · Doak Walker Award · Maxwell Award	Returning lead back gives the offense a proven high-level run-game anchor behind the rebuilt line.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Bryce Fitzgerald	S	● National high-end safety / defensive centerpiece	Walter Camp second team · ACC first team · Bronko Nagurski Trophy · Jim Thorpe Award	The strongest returning secondary recognition signal.
Ahmad Moten Sr.	DL	● High-end conference interior defender	ACC first team · Bednarik Award · Bronko Nagurski Trophy · Outland Trophy	The most recognized returning interior anchor in a front replacing Bain/Mesidor.
Mohamed Toure	LB	● High-end conference linebacker	ACC first team · Butkus Award	Provides proven/recognized second-level stability after Wesley Bissainthe's NFL departure.
Samson Okunlola	OL	● High-end conference offensive lineman	ACC first team	The most recognized returning blocker and essential anchor for a line with two open spots.
◆ Damon Wilson II (TR: Missouri)	DL	● Transfer starter / edge replacement piece	Bednarik Award	Missouri transfer is the headline new front player tasked with replacing some of the disruption lost with DL Rueben Bain Jr./DL Akheem Mesidor.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Manageable for a top-seven team.
Difficulty	● 6/10 · SP+ SOS No. 49
Hardest stretch	at Clemson -> Florida State -> Pittsburgh -> at North Carolina -> at Notre Dame
Swing games	at Notre Dame, at Clemson
Advantage	The bye comes immediately after the Clemson trip, and four of the final five games are at home.
Expected	10.0 wins · likely 10-2
Floor / ceiling	8-4 / 12-0

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	Miami's No. 7 AP/SP+ consensus and 13-win 2025 record will make it difficult to find broad "sleeper" pricing.
Back them when	The price reflects line/front transition risk.
Fade/pass when	Asked to lay an elite premium before the final OL five and kicker are settled.
Key monitor	final OL five, receiver order after WR Cam Vaughn dismissal, kicker winner, new front-seven snap distribution, late availability, Stanford live market price
Week 1 baseline	Miami -22.5 at Stanford · rating-only baseline; Miami primer +22.0 minus Stanford primer -2.5 minus 2.0 default road/home-field adjustment; no matchup or availability adjustment. Compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Miami -24.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Miami still looks like a playoff-caliber team because QB Darian Mensah joins an elite skill core led by WR Malachi Toney/RB Mark Fletcher Jr., while the defense returns enough recognized talent to remain high-end after a dominant 2025. The 2025 profile was genuinely elite on both sides by opponent-adjusted efficiency, so this is not a projection built only on brand or record.

The main question is whether Miami can absorb premium trench losses without slipping too far. Two OL jobs remain open and first-round DL Rueben Bain Jr./DL Akheem Mesidor are gone; with a manageable **SP+ SOS No. 49**, the **10.0-win / 10-2** baseline is realistic if those replacements hold up.

About this primer

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